Compassion and Happiness

I. Introduction

Welcome to the “Compassion and Happiness” data visualization project. In this project, we shall explore the relationship between compassion and happiness at country level to understand whether countries with higher compassion also tend to report higher happiness.

Both the compassion and happiness scores range incrementally from 0 to 10, with 10 indicating the population's highly favorable sentiment regarding compassion or happiness. The happiness score is sourced from the World Happiness Report, whereas the compassion score is calculated based on the survey answers towards questions related to their compassion values such as their sense of collectivism. Due to the limited number of countries with respondents, we only have about 80 country data in our analysis.

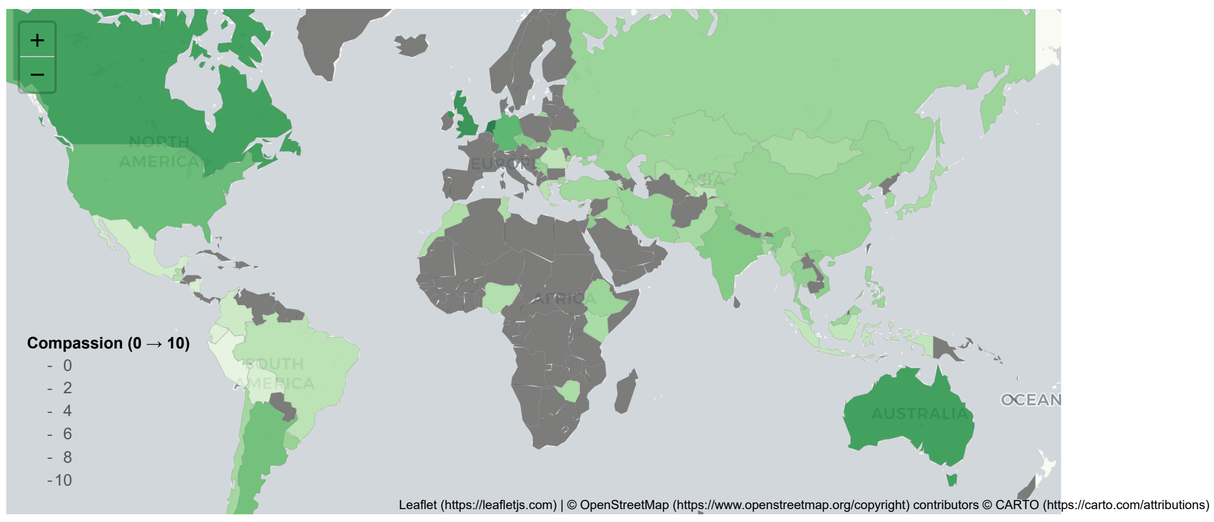
To enrich our understanding of the relationship between these two variables, we shall also analyze their interactions across other socio economic related features as well such as: GDP per capita, Gini index (level of inequality), Net Social Spending as % of GDP (only OECD data available).

II. Overview

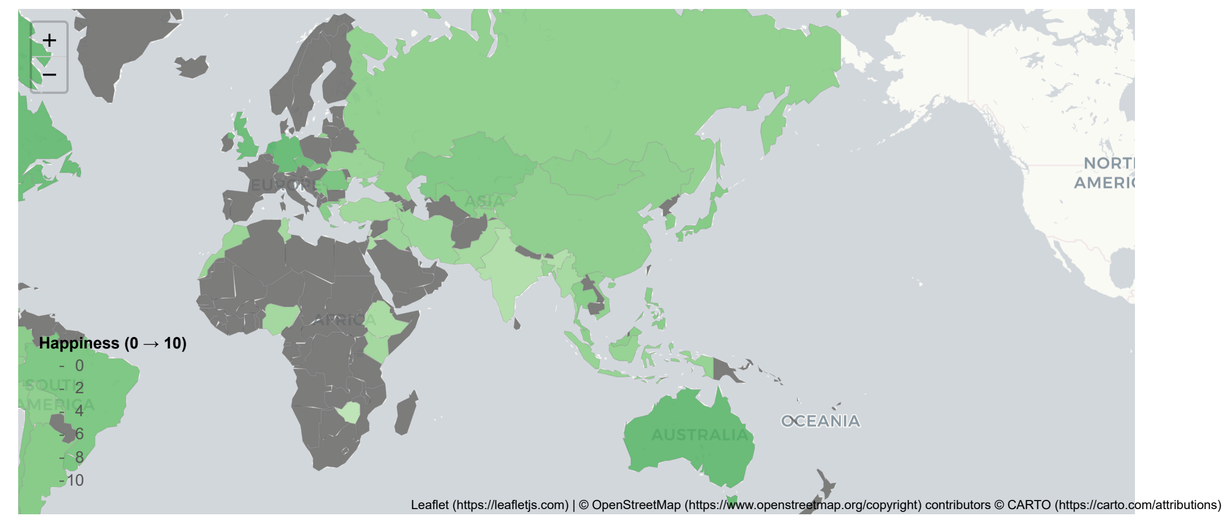
Back Next

Slide 1: Compassion and Happiness Scores across the World

Compassion



Happiness



Description:

The choropleth maps above depict the distribution of compassion and happiness scores across the world.

Most of the countries have a compassion score of at least 4, but there are some countries with score below this mostly from South America. The countries with very high compassion score tend to come from wealthy developed countries in North America, Europe, and Oceania. Besides these countries, the rest exhibit moderate (around 4-6) compassion score.

On the Happiness Score side, most countries have moderate happiness (4 to 6), whereas similarly as compassion, the happiest countries tend to be wealthy countries located in the above mentioned continents. One thing to note is that the countries with low compassion score in South America also exhibit moderate happiness level despite the low compassion score.

This result suggests that there appear to be some connection between compassion and happiness depending on the region as well as the wealth of that region.

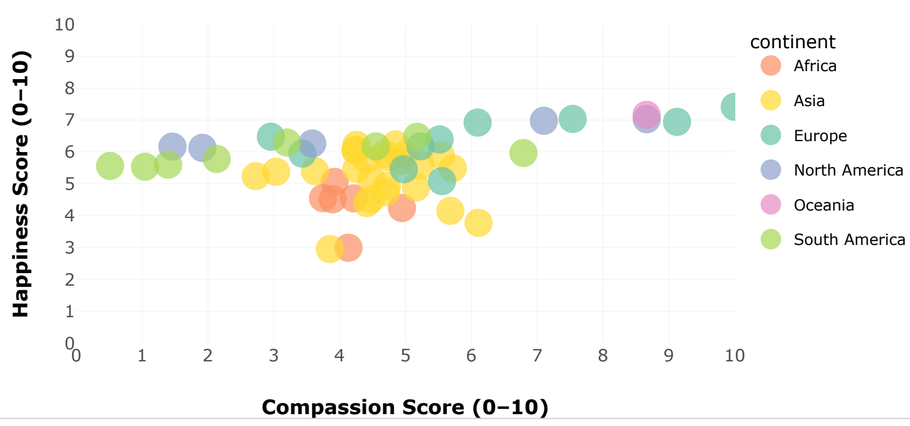
III. Relationship between Compassion and Happiness

Select Continents:

Africa Asia Europe North America Oceania South America

Bubble Size Feature:

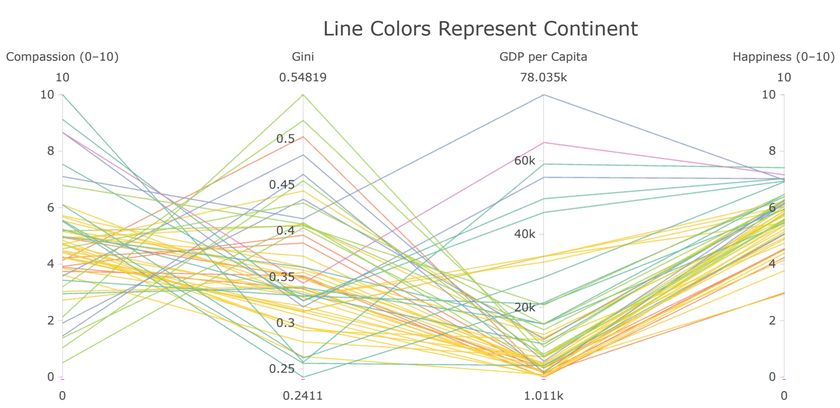
None



Bubble Plot Analysis:

For Europe (green), North America (blue), Oceania (pink), and South America (light-green), you can clearly see a gentle upward trend: as average Compassion rises from about 3–4 up toward 8–10, their Happiness scores also tick up, but only modestly. In other words, those regions show a weak positive correlation with a small slope. By contrast, the Asian (yellow) and African (orange) points are all over the place: at a Compassion score of 4–5, some Asian countries report Happiness near 3 while others report values above 6, and African countries show similar spread. That high vertical variance for the same Compassion level indicates that, for Asia and Africa, empathy alone is not a strong predictor of national well-being as other socioeconomic or cultural factors might be at play.

Features Parallel Correlation



Features Correlation Matrix

Compassion and Happiness Analysis

When viewed together, the parallel-coordinates and correlation-matrix plots reveal a clear multivariate pattern: Compassion only translates into higher Happiness in the context of wealth and low inequality. The heatmap shows that Compassion and Happiness correlate only weakly on their own (r = 0.35), whereas GDP per capita drives Happiness much more strongly (r = 0.67) and is itself tightly linked to Compassion (r = 0.65) and inversely to Gini (r = –0.44). In the parallel-coords, Europe, North America, and Oceania (green, blue, and pink lines) all bundle together at high GDP (20–80 k) and low Gini (0.25–0.40), with Compassion of 6–10 and Happiness of 6–8. By contrast, Asia and Africa (yellow and orange) fan out across Gini and GDP—many low-income, high-inequality countries report similar Compassion scores (3–5) but wildly different Happiness (3–7). In other words, high empathy only delivers high wellbeing when underpinned by economic resources and more equitable income distribution; without those, a compassionate populace may still struggle to achieve greater happiness.